

Word family: **mother / mothers / mothered / mothering / motherhood / motherly / maternal**

Base word: mother

Plural: mothers

Verb forms: mother, mothers, mothered, mothering

Related forms: motherhood, motherly, maternal

Useful compounds/extensions: mother's side, birth mother, biological mother, adoptive mother, foster mother, expectant mother, mother-to-be, mother figure, mother tongue, mother country, mother ship, mother nature, mother company / parent company

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / related adjective and noun forms (相關形容詞及名詞)

Your passage contains:

> "An old person I know well is my grandmother on my **mother's side**."

Here, **mother** means:

your female parent.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **my mother's side**

mother refers to:

the speaker's female parent.

And:

> **my mother's side of the family**

means:

the relatives connected through the speaker's mother rather than the father.

Meaning: A female parent.

繁體中文: **母親；媽媽；這裡指母系一方的家庭**

中文翻譯:

> “my grandmother on my mother’s side”

「我**媽媽那邊的外婆 / 母系祖母**」

So:

mother’s side = 母親那一邊 / 母系一方

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. **mother = female parent (母親) — 母親 ; 媽媽**

This is the exact core meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A female parent.

Practice 1 — Original

> “She is my grandmother on my **mother’s side**.”

「她是我**媽媽那邊的外婆**。」

Practice 2

> “My **mother** lives nearby.”

「我**媽媽**住在附近。」

Practice 3

> “She became a **mother** at the age of thirty.”

「她三十歲時成為了**母親**。」

mother = 女性家長 / 母親

2. **someone’s mother (某人的媽媽) — 母親**

Practice 4

> “Her **mother** taught her how to cook.”

「她的**母親**教她煮飯。」

Practice 5

> “I called my mother yesterday.”

「我昨天打電話給**媽媽**。」

someone's mother = 某人的女性家長

This remains the same core parental sense.

3. **mother's side (母系一方) — 媽媽那邊的親屬**

A major family-expression extension and the exact construction in your passage.

Practice 6

> “Most of my relatives on my **mother's side** live nearby.”

「我**媽媽那邊**的大部分親戚都住在附近。」

Practice 7

> “I get my dark hair from my mother's side of the family.”

「我的黑頭髮是遺傳自**母系家族**。」

mother's side = 與母親一方有親屬關係的家庭 / 家族支系

This is not a separate lexical meaning of **mother**, but it is an essential family construction.

4. **birth mother (生母) — 親生母親**

A useful compound.

Practice 8

> “She later contacted her **birth mother**.”

「她後來聯絡了自己的**生母**。」

Practice 9

> “He knows very little about his birth mother.”

「他對自己的**親生母親**所知不多。」

birth mother = 生下某人的女性；用來與 adoptive mother 等身份區分

5. **biological mother (生物學上的母親) — 生母；親生母親**

Practice 10

> “Her **biological mother** lives abroad.”

「她的**生母**住在海外。」

Practice 11

> “The records identify his biological mother.”

「紀錄列出了他的**親生母親**。」

biological mother = 與某人在生物學 / 遺傳上具有母子女關係的女性

Often overlaps with:

> birth mother.

6. **adoptive mother (養母) — 養母**

Practice 12

> “She was raised by her **adoptive mother**.”

「她由**養母**撫養長大。」

Practice 13

> “Her adoptive mother supported her throughout childhood.”

「她的**養母**在她童年期間一直支持她。」

****adoptive mother = 透過正式收養關係成為某人母親的女性****

7. ****foster mother (寄養母親) — 寄養家庭中的母親****

Practice 14

> “His ****foster mother**** cared for him for several years.”

「他的****寄養母親****照顧了他幾年。」

Practice 15

> “She remained close to her foster mother.”

「她一直與自己的****寄養母親****很親近。」

****foster mother = 在寄養安排中照顧孩子、但通常不是其生母或正式養母的女性****

8. ****expectant mother / mother-to-be (準媽媽) — 準媽媽；孕婦****

A common extension.

Practice 16

> “The class is designed for ****expectant mothers****.”

「這個課程是為****準媽媽 / 孕婦****而設。」

Practice 17

> “The mother-to-be was excited about the baby.”

「這位****準媽媽****對寶寶的出生十分期待。」

****expectant mother / mother-to-be = 正在懷孕、即將成為母親的女性****

9. ****mother = woman who performs a maternal role (像母親般照顧的人) — 母親般的人****

A broader social sense.

Practice 18

> “She was like a ****mother**** to the younger children.”

「她對年幼的孩子來說，就像一位****母親****。」

Practice 19

> “She became a mother to children who needed support.”

「她像****母親**一樣照顧****那些需要支持的孩子**。」

****mother** = 即使沒有生物學母女 / 母子關係，仍承擔照顧、保護和培育角色的女性******

10. ****mother figure** (母親般的人物) — 母親形象；像母親般照顧的人******

A major compound.

Practice 20

> “My grandmother was a ****mother figure**** to me.”

「我的外婆對我來說是一個****母親般的人物****。」

Practice 21

> “She became a mother figure for the younger members of the team.”

「她成為團隊中較年輕成員的****母親般人物****。」

****mother figure** = 在情感、照顧或指導上扮演類似母親角色的人******

The person need not actually be someone’s mother.

11. ****mother** = verb: care for like a mother (像母親般照顧) — 母親般照料******

Now ****mother**** is a verb.

****Meaning:**** To care for, protect, or look after someone in a strongly maternal way.

Practice 22

> “She tended to ****mother**** the younger members of the group.”

「她常常像****母親般照顧****團隊裡較年輕的人。」

Practice 23

> “He doesn’t need you to mother him.”

「他不需要你像****媽媽一樣事事照顧他****。」

****mother someone = 像母親般照顧、保護或關懷某人****

Depending on context, it can be affectionate or slightly critical.

12. ****mother = fuss over / overprotect (過度照顧) — 像媽媽般管得太多****

A common pragmatic extension of the verb.

Practice 24

> “Stop ****mothering**** me—I can take care of myself.”

「別再像媽媽一樣****事事管著 / 照顧我****，我可以照顧自己。」

Practice 25

> “She has a habit of mothering everyone.”

「她習慣把每個人都當孩子般****照顧得無微不至****。」

****mother someone = 過度關照 / 保護某人，好像對方不能自行照顧自己****

This can carry mild annoyance.

13. ****mothering (母親般的照料) — 照顧；母性照料****

Practice 26

> “The child needed warmth and ****mothering****.”

「那個孩子需要溫暖和****母親般的照顧****。」

Practice 27

> “She has a naturally mothering manner.”

「她的態度天生很有**照顧人的母性**。」

mothering = 像母親般照料、保護和關心別人的行為

14. **motherhood (母親身份 / 母職) — 母親身份；做母親的經驗**

A major related noun.

Practice 28

> “She wrote about her experience of **motherhood**.”

「她寫下了自己的**母親生活 / 做母親的經驗**。」

Practice 29

> “Motherhood changed her priorities.”

「**成為母親**改變了她的人生優先次序。」

motherhood = 作為母親的身份、狀態和生活經驗

15. **motherly (母親般慈愛的) — 慈母般的；充滿母愛的**

A useful adjective.

Practice 30

> “She gave me a **motherly hug**.”

「她給了我一個**慈母般的擁抱**。」

Practice 31

> “Her motherly warmth made everyone comfortable.”

「她**母親般的溫暖**令大家都很自在。」

****motherly = 顯示出通常與慈愛母親聯想到的關懷、溫柔和保護****

16. ****maternal (母親的 / 母系的) — 母親方面的 ; 母性的****

A major related adjective, usually more formal than ****motherly****.

Practice 32

> “My ****maternal grandmother**** lives nearby.”

「我的****外婆 / 母系祖母****住在附近。」

Practice 33

> “She felt a strong maternal instinct.”

「她有很強的****母性本能****。」

****maternal = 與母親、母系親屬或母性有關****

This is particularly relevant to your passage.

17. ****maternal grandmother (外婆 / 母系祖母) — 母親的母親****

Practice 34

> “She is my ****maternal grandmother****.”

「她是我的****外婆 / 母系祖母****。」

Practice 35

> “I was very close to my maternal grandmother.”

「我跟自己的****外婆****非常親近。」

****maternal grandmother = your mother’s mother****

This is the formal compact equivalent of:

> grandmother on my mother’s side.

18. **maternal side (母系一方) — 母親那邊的家族**

Practice 36

> “There are many teachers on my **maternal side**.”

「我**母系家族**裡有很多老師。」

Practice 37

> “The tradition comes from her maternal side.”

「這個傳統來自她的**母系一方**。」

maternal side = 與母親血緣 / 家庭一方有關

19. **mother = source/origin of something (根源 / 源頭 ; 比喻) — 根源 ; 孕育者**

A major figurative meaning.

Meaning: Something regarded as the source from which another thing develops.

Practice 38

> “Necessity is sometimes called the **mother of invention**.”

「人們有時說需要是發明的**母親 / 根源**。」

Practice 39

> “The city became the mother of a new artistic movement.”

「這座城市成為一場新藝術運動的**發源地 / 孕育者**。」

mother = 比喻上指產生、孕育或促成其他事物的來源

This is not about literal parenthood.

20. **the mother of all... (極其巨大 / 典型的.....) — 超級 ; 最大規模的**

A common informal hyperbolic expression.

Practice 40

> “They faced **the mother of all storms**.”

「他們遇上了一場**超級猛烈的暴風雨**。」

Practice 41

> “That was the mother of all traffic jams.”

「那是一場**超級嚴重的大塞車**。」

the mother of all X = 非正式誇張地表示某類事物中極大、極強或極典型的一個

Informal.

21. **Mother Nature** (大自然 ; 人格化) — 大自然

A major conventional expression.

Practice 42

> “You cannot control **Mother Nature**.”

「你無法控制**大自然**。」

Practice 43

> “Mother Nature can be unpredictable.”

「**大自然**有時難以預測。」

Mother Nature = 把自然界人格化為母親形象的傳統表達

Usually capitalized.

22. **mother tongue** (母語) — 母語 ; 第一語言

A major lexicalized compound.

Practice 44

> “Cantonese is her **mother tongue**.”

「廣東話是她的**母語**。」

Practice 45

> “People often express emotion differently in their mother tongue.”

「人們用自己的**母語**表達情感時，方式往往有所不同。」

****mother tongue = 一個人早期自然習得、通常最具根基的語言****

It does not literally mean:

> the language spoken by your mother.

23. ****mother language (母語 / 源語言；較少用) — 母語 / 母體語言****

Practice 46

> “The term ****mother tongue**** is much more common in everyday English.”

「日常英語中 ****mother tongue**** 遠比 ****mother language**** 常見。」

Practice 47

> “In linguistics, a parent language can be the source of daughter languages.”

「語言學中，某個祖語可以是其他語言的源頭。」

For learners:

> ****mother tongue****

is the key expression to retain.

24. ****mother country (祖國 / 母國) — 祖國；母國****

A traditional expression.

Practice 48

> “Many immigrants maintained ties with their **mother country**.”

「許多移民仍與自己的**祖國 / 母國**保持聯繫。」

Practice 49

> “The expression mother country can sound historical in some contexts.”

「**mother country** 在某些語境中可能帶較強的歷史色彩。」

mother country = 被視為某人、群體或殖民地來源的祖國 / 母國**

Learners should recognize it, though **home country** is often more neutral in everyday modern English.

25. **mother ship / mothership (母艦 / 母船) — 母艦 ; 母船 ; 母機**

A useful compound.

Practice 50

> “The smaller boats returned to the **mother ship**.”

「較小的船返回了**母船**。」

Practice 51

> “The spacecraft returned to the mothership.”

「太空船返回了**母艦 / 母船**。」

mothership = 供其他較小船隻、飛行器或裝置依附、補給或出發的主要載具**

The concept is figuratively:

> a “parent/source” vehicle.

26. **mother company (母公司) — 母公司**

This expression exists, although **parent company** is generally more idiomatic in standard business English.

Practice 52

> “The subsidiary is controlled by its **parent company**.”

「這家子公司由其**母公司**控制。」

Practice 53

> “In business English, parent company is usually preferred to mother company.”

「商業英語中，一般較常用 **parent company** 表示「母公司」。」

For learner production:

> **parent company** 

is the better default.

27. **motherboard** (主機板 / 主板) — 主機板 ; 主板

A lexicalized technology compound.

Practice 54

> “The computer’s **motherboard** needs replacing.”

「電腦的**主機板 / 主板**需要更換。」

Practice 55

> “The processor is installed on the motherboard.”

「處理器安裝在**主機板**上。」

motherboard = 電腦內連接主要電子元件的核心電路板

The compound metaphorically uses **mother** for a central supporting/base component.

28. **mother cell** (母細胞) — 母細胞

A useful scientific family extension.

Practice 56

> “The **mother cell** divides into new cells.”

「**母細胞**分裂形成新的細胞。」

Practice 57

> “Each daughter cell develops from the mother cell.”

「每個子細胞都由**母細胞**發展而來。」

mother cell = 產生 / 分裂形成其他細胞的原始細胞

This is established but more domain-specific.

29. **mother** = female animal parent (母獸 / 母畜) — 動物的母親

The parental sense naturally applies beyond humans.

Practice 58

> “The puppies stayed close to their **mother**.”

「小狗留在牠們的**母狗 / 媽媽**身邊。」

Practice 59

> “The mother bird fed her chicks.”

「**母鳥**餵食幼鳥。」

mother = 動物的雌性親代

This is still the same underlying parent concept, not a genuinely separate core sense.

Important distinction: **mother** vs mom/mum

mother

= neutral standard word; can sound slightly more formal.

mom

= common informal American English.

mum

= common informal British English and many other varieties.

Compare:

> “My mother is a teacher.”

neutral.

> “My mom/mum is a teacher.”

warmer/more conversational.

Important distinction: **mother vs parent**

mother

= specifically female/maternal parent.

parent

= gender-neutral broader category.

A mother is a parent, but:

> parent

does not specify mother or father.

Important distinction: **mother vs maternal**

mother

is mainly a noun/verb:

> my mother

maternal

is an adjective:

> maternal grandmother

> maternal side

> maternal instinct

So:

> **mother's side**

and:

> **maternal side**

can express the same family direction, but **maternal** is more formal.

Important distinction: **motherly vs maternal**

These overlap but are not identical.

motherly

usually describes behaviour or warmth:

> motherly care

> motherly smile

= 像慈母般的。

maternal

is broader and more formal:

> maternal grandmother

> maternal health

> maternal instinct

= 與母親 / 母系 / 母性有關。

So:

****motherly = 母親般的態度****

****maternal = 母親 / 母系相關****

Important distinction: **mother vs mother figure**

**mother**

may refer to an actual parent.

**mother figure**

= someone who provides mother-like emotional support or guidance without necessarily being the actual mother.

Your grandmother could potentially be:

> a mother figure

if she played that role in someone's life.

Important distinction: **mother someone vs care for someone**

**care for someone**

= look after them generally.

**mother someone**

= care for them specifically in a protective, nurturing, maternal way.

****Mother**** can also imply:

> too much fussing/protection.

So tone matters.

Important distinction: **mother someone vs smother someone**

These words sound similar but are very different.

mother

= nurture/care for like a mother.

smother

can mean:

- * suffocate;
- * cover completely;
- * figuratively overwhelm someone with excessive attention.

> “She mothers him.”

may be caring.

> “She smothers him.”

usually suggests excessive control/attention.

Important distinction: **motherhood vs maternity**

motherhood

= experience/state/identity of being a mother.

maternity

= more formal/institutional term connected with pregnancy and childbirth.

Examples:

> motherhood changed her

but:

> maternity leave

> maternity ward

Different collocations.

Important distinction: ****maternal grandmother vs grandmother on my mother's side****

They mean the same family relationship.

Conversational:

> "my grandmother on my mother's side"

Compact/formal:

> "my maternal grandmother"

For everyday IELTS-style speaking, the first may sound more natural and accessible.

Important distinction: ****birth mother vs biological mother****

These often overlap.

****birth mother****

focuses on:

> the woman who gave birth.

****biological mother****

focuses on:

> biological/genetic parentage.

In many ordinary contexts they refer to the same person, but the emphasis differs.

Important distinction: ****adoptive mother vs foster mother****

****adoptive mother****

= parent through adoption.

****foster mother****

= caregiver within a foster-care arrangement, usually without the same permanent legal parent status.

These should not be confused.

Important distinction: ****mother tongue vs mother's language****

****mother tongue****

= native/first language.

It does ****not necessarily mean****:

> the language your mother personally speaks.

Someone may acquire a mother tongue from:

- * family;
- * community;
- * environment;

not only the mother.

So the compound is lexicalized.

Important distinction: ****mother tongue vs first language****

These often overlap strongly.

****mother tongue****

= traditional/common expression emphasizing native linguistic roots.

****first language / L1****

= more neutral linguistic/educational terminology.

For multilingual people, the situation can be more complex than one single "mother tongue."

Important distinction: ****mother country vs home country****

mother country

= traditional/historical expression emphasizing origin or ancestral/political source.

home country

= neutral everyday term for the country someone regards as home/is from.

For ordinary modern learner production:

> **home country**

is often safer.

Important distinction: **Mother Nature vs nature**

nature

= the natural world.

Mother Nature

= personifies nature as though it were a female/maternal being.

> "Nature is unpredictable."

neutral.

> "Mother Nature had other plans."

more figurative/personified.

Important distinction: **mother = parent vs mother = source**

Compare:

> "She is my mother."

= literal family relationship.

versus:

> “Necessity is the mother of invention.”

= source/origin metaphor.

The second does not imply a literal biological relationship.

Important distinction: **“the mother of all X”**

This expression does **not** mean:

> the literal parent/source of X.

In modern informal usage:

> **“the mother of all storms”**

means:

> an exceptionally huge/intense storm.

So context distinguishes:

> origin metaphor

from:

> emphatic hyperbole.

Important distinction: **“motherboard vs mother”**

“Motherboard” is a lexicalized compound.

It should not be parsed for everyday meaning as:

> “a board that is a mother.”

Instead:

> it is the computer’s central circuit board.

This belongs in the family sweep, not as a new bare **“mother”** sense.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **mother** family includes parental identity, maternal behaviour, source metaphors, and several established compounds:

- * **mother — female parent** = 母親 / 媽媽
- * **mother's side** = 母親一方 / 母系家族
- * **birth mother** = 生母
- * **biological mother** = 親生母親
- * **adoptive mother** = 養母
- * **foster mother** = 寄養母親
- * **expectant mother** = 準媽媽 / 孕婦
- * **mother-to-be** = 準媽媽
- * **mother figure** = 母親般的人物
- * **mother — verb** = 像母親般照顧
- * **mothering** = 母親般的照料
- * **motherhood** = 母親身份 / 做母親的經驗
- * **motherly** = 慈母般的 / 充滿母愛的
- * **maternal** = 與母親 / 母系 / 母性有關
- * **maternal grandmother** = 外婆 / 母系祖母
- * **maternal side** = 母系一方
- * **mother — source/origin** = 來源 / 孕育者
- * **mother of invention** = 發明的根源 (固定比喻)
- * **the mother of all X** = 超級 / 極端的 X
- * **Mother Nature** = 大自然 (人格化)
- * **mother tongue** = 母語
- * **mother country** = 母國 / 祖國 (較傳統)
- * **mothership** = 母艦 / 母船
- * **motherboard** = 主機板 / 主板
- * **mother cell** = 母細胞
- * **mother company** = 母公司，但商業英語通常更偏好 **parent company**

The main semantic branches are:

- > **female parent**
- > **person performing a maternal/nurturing role**
- > **verb: care for someone maternally**
- > **source/origin metaphor**

plus established compounds where **mother** means:

> **original, central, nurturing, or source-related**

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
mother — parent	某人的女性家長 / 母親
mother's side	與某人母親一方有親屬關係的家庭支系
birth mother	生下某人的女性，常用來與養母等身份區分
biological mother	與某人在生物學 / 遺傳上具有母子女關係的女性
adoptive mother	透過正式收養關係成為某人母親的女性
foster mother	在寄養安排中負責照顧孩子的女性
expectant mother	正在懷孕、即將成為母親的女性
mother figure	沒有必要是實際母親，但在情感 / 照顧上扮演母親角色的人
mother — verb	像母親般照顧、保護、關心某人；有時可暗示照顧過度
motherhood	作為母親的身份、狀態和生活經驗
motherly	顯示慈愛母親般的關心、溫柔或保護
maternal	與母親、母系親屬或母性有關
maternal grandmother	一個人的母親的母親；外婆 / 母系祖母
mother — source/origin	比喻上產生、孕育或促成其他事物的來源
the mother of all X	非正式誇張地表示某類事物中極大、極強的一個
Mother Nature	把自然界人格化成母親形象的表達
mother tongue	一個人早期自然習得、最具根基的語言；母語
mother country	被視為某人 / 群體來源的祖國 / 母國；用語較傳統
mothership	供其他較小載具出發、依附或補給的主要載具
motherboard	電腦內連接主要電子元件的核心電路板
mother cell	能分裂 / 產生其他細胞的原始細胞

For your original passage

> “An old person I know well is my grandmother on my **mother's side**.”

The exact meaning is:

mother = your female parent

and:

mother's side = the branch of your family connected through your mother

Therefore:

> **my grandmother on my mother's side**

= **「我媽媽那邊的外婆」**

A compact formal alternative is:

> **my maternal grandmother**

= **我的外婆 / 母系祖母**

For natural speaking, however:

> **my grandmother on my mother's side**

is very clear and conversational.

The most important learner contrasts are:

> **my mother**

> = 我的媽媽

> **my mother's side**

> = 我媽媽那邊的家族

> **my maternal grandmother**

> = 我的外婆

> **birth mother**

> = 生母

> **adoptive mother**

> = 養母

> **foster mother**

> = 寄養母親

> **mother figure**

> = 母親般的人物

> **mother someone**

> = 像母親般照顧某人

> **motherhood**

> = 母親身份 / 做母親的經驗

> ****motherly****

> = 慈母般的

> ****maternal****

> = 母親 / 母系相關的

> ****mother tongue****

> = 母語

> ****Mother Nature****

> = 大自然

> ****mother of invention****

> = 某事物的根源 / 孕育者

> ****the mother of all storms****

> = 超級猛烈的暴風雨

> ****mothership****

> = 母艦 / 母船

> ****motherboard****

> = 主機板

So ****mother**** is richer than simply:

> ****mother = 母親****

but its core meanings should still be kept conservative:

1. ****female parent****
2. ****person/verb involving maternal care****
3. ****figurative source or origin****

The numerous compounds are useful family extensions rather than excuses to invent dozens of separate bare-word senses.

And in your original passage it specifically means:

****“the speaker’s female parent, with ‘my mother’s side’ identifying the maternal branch of the family.”****